BACK TO THE FUTURE

On May 15, Congress leader **Rahul Gandhi** quietly took a seat at a Patna theatre to watch *Phule*, the biopic of 19th-century social reformers Jyotirao and Savitribai Phule. The timing was no accident; the film goes well with his social justice and OBC empowerment pitch. Interestingly, this was Rahul's fourth visit to Bihar this year. Groundwork for the assembly election ahead, or a belated response to the 2020 jibe of his being "more tourist than campaigner"?



Man in Demand



His party may have got out for a duck in the assembly election, but Maharashtra Navnirman Sena chief **Raj Thackeray** is much sought after by everyone these days. After Raj spoke about patching up with estranged cousin and Shiv Sena UBT president Uddhav Thackeray, Maharashtra industries minister and Shiv Sena (Shinde) leader Uday Samant met him at his residence at Dadar in Mumbai. Though Samant said he met the MNS chief for tea and *khichdi*, the buzz is that a whole new political *khichdi* is being cooked.

ON TIME, PLEASE



A Railway Board circular that top officers must also adhere to biometric attendance rules to promote "discipline and accountability" has stirred up a debate in the power corridors, especially the part about a 9.15 am fall-in, and attendance records going for central review. In a world of flexi-hours and remote working, the old-school biometric scanner is also a sign of a tightening of the screws. Guess the Rail Bhawan clocks will get some extra shine in the coming days.

Kaushik Deka with Amitabh Srivastava, Avaneesh Mishra, Dhaval S. Kulkarni and Avishek G. Dastidar

HEALTH WATCH

By **Sonali Acharjee**

HEART ATTACKS PLASTIC TAKES A DEADLY TOLL

It's common knowledge that plastic is killing us slowly, but now there's proof that they even cause heart attacks. And India is the worst affected, accounting for almost a third of the global fatalities linked to DEHP-related cardiovascular diseases. And what is DEHP? Di-(2-ethylhexyl) phthalate is part of plastic compounds known as phthalates, a group of synthetic chemicals used as plasticisers to increase flexibility and durability in plastics, particularly the popular PVC (polyvinyl chloride). DEHP is the most commonly used phthalate.



SHUTTERSTOCK

Till now, the medical community believed DEHP to be harmful for hormonal wellbeing. But a study published recently in *The Lancet's* eBioMedicine journal has identified a significant link between exposure to DEHP and heart disease-related deaths. Researchers at NYU Langone Health analysed urine samples and environmental data from over 200 countries. They found that in 2018, DEHP exposure was associated with 356,238 deaths in the 55-64 age group. India accounted for 103,587 of these deaths. In comparison, China, also a major producer/consumer of plastics, recorded 33,858 fatalities.

The researchers attribute India's high mortality to the rapid expansion of its plastics industry, widespread use of DEHP-containing products and weak regulatory controls. While the FSSAI has established specific migration limits for DEHP in food contact plastics, the amount that can 'migrate' into food is set at 1.5 mg/kg. In the EU, not only is DEHP banned in any material containing fatty food (where the leaching rates are higher), the migration limit is set at 0.6 mg/kg.